
Plain-English Map — What “Testing” and “Publishing” Actually Mean, and Your Rollout

Cameron — this is the one page to read when the app stores feel like a maze. No tech words without a plain translation. If anything here ever feels confusing, that’s on the page, not on you. Read it once and you’ll understand the whole thing.

THE ONE BIG IDEA (READ THIS FIRST)

There are only **two states** an app can be in:

1. **Testing** — only people YOU invite can get it. The public cannot find it or search for it. It is private, on purpose.
2. **Published** (also called **Production** or “going live”) — anyone in the world can search the store and download it.

Right now your app is in TESTING. That is correct. That is where it is supposed to be. You are not trying to publish to the whole world yet. You are getting a small, trusted group to use it first. So when the stores don’t show your app to the public — good. That’s the plan working, not something broken.

THE WORDS, DECODED

The stores use insider words for simple things. Here is every word you’ll see, in plain terms:

- **Internal testing** — your own tiny circle (just you and maybe one or two people). Instant, no waiting. *This is how the app is on YOUR Android phone right now.*
- **Closed testing** — a named list of people you invite by email. **This is the one your church rollout uses.** They get the app and keep it. This is what people mean by “the official testing phase.”
- **Open testing** — anyone with a link can join. (You’re not using this.)
- **Production / Public release / Go live** — the real, public store. The final step. (Later.)
- **TestFlight** — this is just *Apple’s word* for testing. It was how iPhones got the app before Apple approved it; now the iPhone app is simply on the public App Store, so this word matters less every day.
- **“In review” / “Waiting for review”** — the company (Apple or Google) is looking it over before letting it go public. This is normal. It just means *waiting in line*. There is nothing for you to do while it says this.

That’s the whole vocabulary. There isn’t more.

WHY THERE’S A “2-WEEK” THING (THE HONEST REASON — AND WHY IT HELPS YOU)

Google has a rule for a personal developer account like yours: **before they will let you go public, at least 12 people you invited have to keep your app installed and opted-in for 14 days in a row.** It’s a box Google makes you check to prove real people use the app.

This is the “2-week testing phase.” It is a **real Google requirement**, not something you made up. Which is exactly why it’s a great thing to tell people:

“You’d be one of the official testers Google needs actively using the app for two weeks, so it can launch to the public.”

Every word of that is true. You’re not overselling — you’re describing a real rule. That’s what makes your invitation both honest and exciting.

“NOT A TIMED TRIAL” — HERE’S WHAT YOUR TESTERS ACTUALLY EXPERIENCE

You were right to care about this. Here is the truth:

On Android: once someone installs from your invite link, the app just stays on their phone. There is no countdown on their screen. No “your trial ends in X days.” Nothing kicks them off. The 14 days is Google’s behind-the-scenes counter, not a clock the user ever sees. They just use the app normally.

On iPhone: no countdown at all anymore — the app is live on the public App Store, a normal permanent install like any other app.

So you can promise people honestly: *install it and keep it — it’s yours, it won’t expire on you.*

WHAT TO SAY TO PEOPLE (TRUE, SIMPLE, AND EXCITING)

You don’t quiz people on their phone brand up front. You get them excited first, then ask the one question you need. Something like:

“I built a faith app — it ministers the way the Savior did, meeting people where they are. It’s in the official testing phase right now, the step before it goes public. Do you have an Android? If you give me your email, I can add you as an official tester. Google actually needs a group of real people using it for two weeks before it can launch — so you’d be in from the very beginning, and you’d genuinely be helping it get off the ground.”

Why this works: it’s all true, it makes them feel chosen (because they are), and the only thing you need back from them is **“yes, and here’s my email.”** That email is the key that lets you add them as a tester.

(If they have an iPhone instead of Android — great, that’s the easy one now: they install straight from the public App Store, no invite. It’s the Android folks whose email you collect.)

HOW TO KNOW “ARE WE GOOD, OR IS SOMETHING WRONG?”

You should never have to decode this alone — that’s my job, and I check the pages and tell you in plain words. But here’s how to read it yourself if you ever want to:

The simple rule: look for the color and the word. - A **red banner**, or the words **“Rejected,” “Action required,”** or **“Issue”** = something needs doing. (Tell me — I’ll handle it.) - **Everything else** — “Waiting for review,” “In review,” “Ready to test,” “Active,” green checkmarks — = you’re fine. It’s just moving through the line.

On the iPhone side (App Store Connect): your app is in and processing correctly. “Waiting for Review” means Apple has it in line. “Ready to Test” means testers can install it. None of those are problems.

On the Android side (Play Console → “Test and release”): a build showing under Internal or Closed testing, marked “Active,” with no red banners, means it’s working. The setup checklist that says “10 of 11 complete” is just a to-do list, not an error.

If you remember one sentence: *no red, no “rejected” = we’re just waiting, and waiting is normal.*

YOUR ROLLOUT, IN THE RIGHT ORDER

This lines up with the rest of this kit. Each step has its own document for the exact words to use.

1. **Now (already in motion):** iPhone is APPROVED and live on the public App Store (July 2026). Android is in testing, ready for Google’s required closed test. Nothing is stuck.
 2. **Family and friends:** Get them excited, collect Android emails. This warms up your tester list before it counts.
 3. **Rich, then Kyle:** Walk it up the priesthood line — see 02_Staged-Approach-Plan.md. Ask for counsel and their blessing, not approval.
 4. **The Bishop (this week):** Ask only for his blessing to let a few priesthood holders test it. Small, honest ask. See the staged plan and 05_FAQ-and-Objections.md.
 5. **The official 2-week closed test:** 12+ testers from the ward keep the app for 14 days straight. That’s the gate that unlocks the public launch. Use 03_Priesthood-Invitation-Email.md for the invite — and show the Bishop the exact wording first.
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WHO DOES WHAT (SO NOTHING FALLS ON YOU BY SURPRISE)

I handle: setting up the closed-test track, making the tester invite link, pushing the app build to it, watching the store pages, and translating every status into plain words for you.

You handle: the human conversations, collecting the emails (or just handing them to me), and the single final “go public” button at the very end — the one the stores legally require the account owner to press. I get you all the way to that button and point right at it. I never leave you to figure out a page by yourself.

THE WHOLE THING IN ONE BREATH

You’re in testing, which is exactly right. The “2 weeks” is a real Google rule that makes your tester invite honest and exciting. Nobody gets kicked off — the app stays on their phone. Get people excited, collect Android emails, walk it up the priesthood line to the Bishop, then run the official 2-week test that unlocks the public launch. And you never have to read the maze alone — that’s mine to handle.